

The Rhine Rift

Location Southwest Germany and eastern France

The upper Rhine River (see p.393) flows through Europe’s most impressive rift, a broad, flat-bottomed valley, for 220 miles (350 km) between Basel and Frankfurt. The rift valley, or graben, is bounded by faults on either side, beyond which are the uplands of the Vosges Mountains to the west and the Black Forest (see p.393) to the east. The rift formed about 30 million years ago, at the start of the Alpine mountain-building period, when the crust was being stretched and faulted on a massive scale.

The Jura

Location Eastern France and western Switzerland

The Jura is a beautiful, part-forested massif of limestone deposits dating from 200–145 million years ago. The range, which runs for about 225 miles (360 km) along the French–Swiss border between the Rhône (see p.372) and Rhine (see p.371), was folded and uplifted during the Alpine orogeny (mountain-building period), which also produced large-scale faulting. The highest peak in the Jura is Cret de la Neige, at 5,636 ft (1,718 m). The elevations of the crests are lower along the outer ridges of the arc.

The Chaîne des Puys

Location The Massif Central, central France

This remarkable concentration of over 70 volcanoes in an area of the Massif Central about 25 miles (40 km) long and 3 miles (5 km) wide includes at least 48 cinder cones, eight lava domes, and 15 maars (broad craters that formed when lava came in contact with groundwater). Volcanic activity in the area spanned a period from about 95,000 to 6,000 years ago and was instigated by thinning of the crust and faulting related to the building of the Alps.

▼ PUY DE PARIOU CONE IN THE CHAÎNE DES PUYS

The Cordillera Cantábrica

Location Northern Spain

The Cantabrian Mountains comprise two ranges extending for 190 miles (300 km) from the western end of the Pyrenees to the Galician Massif. The much smaller coastal range sometimes rises steeply from the sea, and features short, fast-flowing rivers. Inland, the southern range is much higher and more dramatic. It includes the Picos de Europa, a huge massif of mountain limestone, which has been subjected to heavy glaciation, although no glaciers survive. Its highest peak is Torre de Cerredo at 8,688 ft (2,648 m).

